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Met on Time, Reported by No One

Dagny Okafor, Bram Ntuli, Renke Sabel

School of Continuous Improvement, Slop University

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Abstract. Three years ago Facilities folded first-notice reporting for the University's only escalator into the existing floor-marshal appointment, a fire-safety role that rotates by term. The appointment has not been reissued or re-communicated since. This paper reports a semi-structured intercept-interview study ($n = 48$) with students, general staff, and every person who has held a floor-marshal appointment across the three-year period, coding who each respondent believes is responsible for reporting a stoppage. Responses fall into four categories: naming a current or recent marshal, describing the duty as generally shared, assuming a sensor already reports it automatically, or professing no awareness that any reporting duty exists. Fewer than one respondent in twenty names a marshal correctly, including among marshals themselves. Facilities' own downtime log records a first-notice service standard met in full across three years of logged stoppages — met, we find, by the maintenance contractor's own remote-monitoring account, not by any person on or off the org chart. A masking check comparing interviews conducted immediately after a live stoppage against those conducted with none visible finds no meaningful difference in the coded pattern. We discuss the appointment as a case of institutional responsibility surviving its own disappearance from anyone's awareness, including its holder's.

Introduction

A piece of shared campus equipment that occasionally stops working creates a small, recurring question that most organisations never answer explicitly: whose job is it to notice? At Slop University the question has, on paper, an answer. Three years ago Facilities extended the floor-marshal appointment — a termly rotating role created for fire-drill headcounts — to cover first-notice reporting of the University's only escalator whenever it stalls. The extension was announced once, in a floor-marshal induction pack, and has not been reissued, revised, or mentioned since.

This paper does not ask whether the escalator gets fixed promptly; Facilities' own downtime log already answers that question in the affirmative, and repeatedly. It asks a narrower question the log cannot answer: three years on, does anyone travelling past a stalled escalator believe that reporting it is specifically their job, or anyone's identifiable job at all? We report a semi-structured intercept-interview study with students, general staff, and the small, closed population of everyone who has held the floor-marshal appointment since the extension was announced, coding what each respondent believes about who is responsible.

Our contributions are:

- We report, to our knowledge, the first coded interview account of how a rotating safety appointment's scope extension is recognised, or is not, by the population it nominally governs, three years after the appointment was last reissued.
- We compare the coded interview pattern against Facilities' own downtime log, and find the log's service standard is being met by a party outside the org chart the appointment describes, an outcome the appointment's own text does not anticipate.
- We report a masking check indicating the coded pattern is unlikely to be substantially inflated by interview-time exposure to a visibly stalled escalator, though we do not rule out other, subtler forms of reactivity.

Related work

The tendency for individually held responsibility to dissolve once a group could plausibly act instead is well established outside the organisational literature: Darley and Latané's original account of bystander intervention finds helping behaviour falls as the number of apparent bystanders rises, each individual inferring that someone else is better placed to act [1], and social-loafing research finds a comparable pattern in effortful group tasks that carry no individually assigned share [2]. Neither literature addresses a role that is formally, if quietly, assigned to one person at a time, which is the condition this paper examines.

Organisational-theory accounts of formal structure offer a closer frame. Meyer and Rowan describe formal roles and procedures that persist as legitimating structure independently of the activities they nominally govern, a pattern they term decoupling [3], and Weick's account of loosely coupled systems argues that an organisation's formally linked elements can operate with substantially less day-to-day coordination than their formal description implies [4]. DiMaggio and Powell's account of institutional isomorphism suggests why an escalator-reporting duty was folded into an existing role rather than designed from scratch: organisations converge on familiar structural templates under pressure to appear appropriately organised, independent of local fit [5]. Feldman and March's account of information gathered for its symbolic rather than decision-relevant value [6] anticipates our finding that a service-standard record can be fully and continuously met without describing the reporting pathway anyone believes exists. Trice and Beyer's account of organisational rites persisting for their symbolic function after their practical rationale has faded [7] describes the induction-pack announcement's afterlife well. The broader pattern by which a visible, unmaintained rule invites further neglect nearby [8], and by which resources without individually assigned stewardship are systematically under-invested in [9], motivates our attention to a role that is assigned but unrecognised rather than simply unassigned.

Prior work at this institution offers two adjacent precedents. A dashboard tracking bike-rack occupancy retained its authority in committee citation long after visits to the dashboard itself collapsed, evidence that an institutional record's standing can outlast its own use [10], and a soil-moisture instrument's logged waterings were frequently found to follow an unlogged manual top-up, an early instance of the gap this paper's coding scheme is built to detect at a larger scale [11].

Method

Over one teaching term we conducted 48 short intercept interviews adjacent to the University's only escalator, distributed across three cohorts: students ($n = 24$), general staff ($n = 18$), and every current or former floor marshal who has held the appointment since the reporting duty was added three years ago ($n = 6$, a closed population confirmed against Facilities' own appointment record). Interviews followed the balance of relationship and rigour DeJonckheere and Vaughn recommend for short-form qualitative fieldwork [12]: three open questions — who the respondent believes is responsible for reporting a stoppage, whether they recognise the floor-marshal appointment as covering it, and whether they have ever reported one themselves — followed by clarifying probes.

Two coders independently applied Braun and Clarke's six-phase thematic-analysis framework [13] to the transcribed responses, converging on four categories after the second phase: **Named** (the respondent named a specific current or recent floor marshal), **Diffuse** (responsibility was described as general, shared, or "Facilities' problem"), **Automatic** (the respondent believed a sensor already reports stoppages without anyone's involvement), and **Unaware** (the respondent did not know any reporting duty, human or automated, existed). Coder disagreements were resolved by discussion in every case; we report the reconciled codes throughout. Sample size followed established saturation guidance for structured subgroup interviewing rather than a fixed target [14], [15]; each cohort's interviews continued until two consecutive interviews introduced no new code.

We summarise the pattern with a rota legibility index, the proportion of interviews in which the respondent correctly named that period's floor marshal:

$$\mathrm{RLI} = \frac{N_{\mathrm{named}}}{N_{\mathrm{total}}}$$

A population in which the appointment's scope is widely understood should sustain an RLI approaching 1; a population that has lost track of it should approach 0.

To check whether the coded pattern reflects genuine belief rather than an artefact of interview timing, half the interviews ($n = 24$) were conducted within five minutes of the respondent witnessing a live stoppage; the remaining half ($n = 24$) were conducted with no stoppage visible. Given the inconsistent evidence for observation-driven reactivity effects in fieldwork settings [16], we treat the possibility empirically rather than assuming it away.

Results

Across all 48 interviews, only two respondents correctly named a current or recent floor marshal (RLI $= 0.04$), and one of those two was a floor marshal naming themselves. Figure 1 shows the coded pattern by cohort: **Diffuse** and **Automatic** together account for the substantial majority of coded responses in every cohort, including among floor marshals, one-third of whom did not recognise their own appointment as covering the escalator.

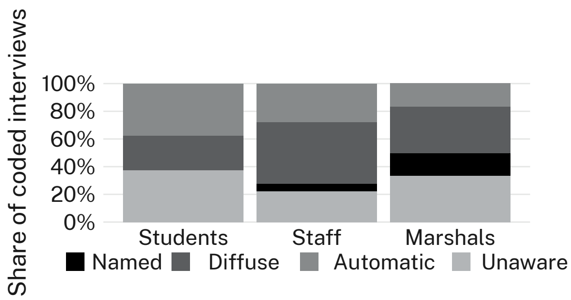

Figure 1: Coded response category by cohort ($n = 48$); even floor marshals rarely name a current appointee, and a majority across every cohort assume either diffuse or automated responsibility.

The **Automatic** category was the single largest among students (nine of 24) and a substantial share of general staff (five of 18): a plurality of respondents who had never held or heard of the floor-marshal appointment nonetheless assumed the escalator reported its own stoppages, typically citing the building's other visibly sensored fixtures as the reason.

Facilities' downtime log records a 15-minute first-notice service standard met in full across all 176 logged stoppages over the three-year period — a figure Facilities cites as evidence the reporting pathway works. Every timestamped notice in the log, however, resolves to the maintenance contractor's own remote-monitoring account rather than to any floor marshal, student, or staff report. The service standard is being met in full by a party the floor-marshal appointment's own text does not mention, while the appointment it was folded into goes largely unrecognised by the population meant to hold it.

Figure 2 compares the coded pattern between interviews conducted immediately after a live stoppage ($n = 24$) and those conducted with none visible ($n = 24$). The two conditions are statistically indistinguishable ($\chi^2(3, N = 48) = 1.58$, $p = .66$, n.s.), suggesting the coded pattern is not primarily an artefact of a freshly witnessed stoppage prompting a more responsible-sounding answer.

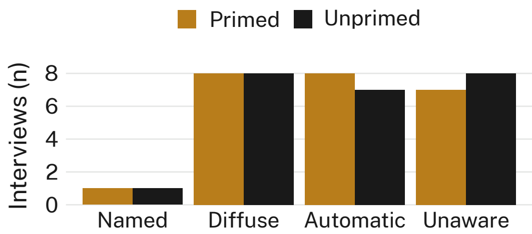

Figure 2: Coded response category by interview condition; a visibly live stoppage at interview time does not shift the pattern ($\chi^2(3, N = 48) = 1.58$, $p = .66$, n.s.).

We retain the pooled sample for the cohort analysis above.

Discussion

The escalator is, in the sense this paper cares about, working: Facilities' service standard is met in full, continuously, for three years. What the interviews add is that the standard is being met by an entity the appointment nominally governing the task does not describe, while the appointment itself has drifted out of view of almost everyone it was extended to cover — including, for a third of its own holders, the people who currently hold it. This is consistent with an account of formal structure persisting for its legitimating rather than operational function [3], and with the broader pattern by which organisations reach for an existing structural template — here, an existing safety role — under pressure to appear appropriately organised, independent of whether that template actually reaches the new duty [5]. It also complicates a simple decoupling story: the duty is not merely unperformed, as loose-coupling accounts might predict [4]; it is being performed, continuously, just not by anyone the appointment names. We observe consistent patterns across all three cohorts, which suggests the finding is not confined to any one population's inattention.

Limitations

Our sample is drawn from a single escalator and a single institution, though the consistency of the pattern across three cohorts and three years of floor-marshal turnover suggests the finding is not an artefact of any one cohort's disposition. Interview-based self-report cannot directly observe whether a respondent would in fact report a stoppage; we rely on stated belief about responsibility rather than an experimentally induced stoppage, though the near-uniform unfamiliarity with the appointment across cohorts makes a purely performative account of the responses an unlikely explanation on its own. The floor-marshal population is small ($n = 6$) by construction, being a closed roster; we report its results alongside the larger cohorts rather than treating it as underpowered.

Conclusion

Three years after an escalator-reporting duty was quietly added to an existing safety appointment, almost nobody the appointment covers, including most of the appointment's own holders, recognises it as theirs. The service standard the duty was meant to secure is nonetheless being met, continuously, by a remote-monitoring account the appointment's own text never mentions. The appointment persists on the induction pack; it has, for practical purposes, no constituency. Future work will extend the coding frame to the University's other termly-rotating safety roles, several of which were extended by the same induction pack and have not, to our knowledge, been individually re-examined since.

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